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(English Lexicology)



Paper Title: Source Languages Systematically Shape the Lexico-Grammatical Profiles of Translated English at Different Linguistic Levels

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Abstract

Toury's Law of Interference predicts that source-language (SL) structures permeate translated texts, yet whether typological proximity linearly scales this interference remains systematically untested. This study examines how SLs shape the lexico-grammatical profiles of translated English through two interacting mechanisms: *Direct Structural Mapping* and *Cognate Camouflage*. Utilizing 16 translational English varieties from the OPUS-100 corpus alongside an original English baseline, we extracted Biber's (1988) 67 features across six functional dimensions. Macro-profiling reveals widely divergent register shapes even within the same language family, and disproves native English as a central attractor, ruling out strong Translation Universals. While the Mantel test confirms a systematic SL influence at the aggregate level driven by phrasal-level mapping, this effect is dimensionally asymmetric. Typological distance measured by the World Atlas of Language Structures (WALS) correlates positively with Biber's informational dimensions, but exhibits a significant negative correlation with clausal-level embedding features. This indicates that distant languages undergo deep reformulation and converge on English norms, whereas closely related languages trigger covert syntactic interference via surface-level lexical transparency (cognate camouflage). Feature-level alignment further validates this asymmetry. We propose a qualified amendment to Toury's Law: SLs systematically shape translational English, but the direction and magnitude of interference depend on the interaction between typological distance and specific lexico-grammatical subsystems.

Keywords: translational English, direct structural mapping, cognate camouflage, Biber dimensions, WALS,

1. Introduction

Translation is a negotiation between two competing forces: source language and target language. However, the underlying mechanisms regulating this negotiation, and whether its intensity scales systematically with structural proximity, remain highly debated. On one side stands Toury's Law of Interference (Toury, 1980). It proposed that source-language structural features permeate target-language output in measurable and predictable ways, and correspondingly, translated language is thought to constitute a systematically distinct textual variety, bearing the dual imprint of its source language and the cognitive mediation process itself.

On the other side stand the Translation Universals identified by Baker (1993) and elaborated by Laviosa (2002). They identified several features in translated English: simplification, the reduction of lexical variety relative to both source and original target-language production; explicitation, the spelling-out of grammatical relations that original writers leave implicit; and normalisation, convergence toward the probabilistic centre of target-language conventions. These universals pull all translational varieties toward a standard target-language norm, making them more homogeneous. Each variety effectively finds its position along a continuum between native English and foreign interference.

While prior work has established that source-language interference exists, it remains crucially silent on how the directionality and magnitude of this interference fluctuates across typologically diverse systems. However, empirical verification remains fragmented: classical studies have heavily relied on single language pairs (Laviosa, 2002); register analyses have restricted their scope to translated versus non-native non-translational English (Kruger & van Rooy, 2016); and recent computational approaches have pursued black-box Transformer-based classifications without grounding their lexical mappings in linguistic theory (Hu et al., 2026). To date, no study has systematically correlated theory-grounded, multi-dimensional lexico-grammatical variations across a comprehensive multi-language matrix against quantified typological distances.

We address this methodological gap by evaluating a rigorously controlled sixteen-language sample extracted from the OPUS-100 parallel corpus, complemented by an original native English baseline to anchor our comparisons. To eliminate noise from ambiguous language tags and domain shifting, we implement a deterministic unambiguous-label filtering pipeline, ensuring that each translational variety reflects a clean, structurally isolated linguistic stream. We then extract Biber’s (1988) 67 linguistically-grounded features for each variety and project them onto six theory-driven functional dimensions. To systematically model the cross-lingual interface, we execute a multi-level Mantel testing framework that directly maps the synchronic structural coordinates of the World Atlas of Language Structures (WALS) against our 67-dimensional Biber feature space across aggregate, dimensional, and individual feature-level representations.

Our findings deliver an empirical resolution to this long-standing debate by rejecting a strong account of Translation Universals while presenting a nuanced refinement of Toury’s framework. To operationalize this inquiry, we first establish a deterministic unambiguous-label filtering pipeline on the OPUS-100 parallel corpus, extracting sixteen distinct translational English varieties alongside an original, native English baseline. Second, we extract Biber’s 67 lexico-grammatical features for each variety (Biber, 1988), mapping them across six theory-driven functional dimensions to capture the full spectrum of register variation (Nini, 2019). Third, we construct a global language typological matrix using synchronic structural coordinates derived from the World Atlas of Language Structures (WALS) (Dryer & Haspelmath, 2013). Finally, we employ a multi-level Mantel testing framework to mathematically intersect these two independent geometric spaces, allowing us to evaluate cross-lingual distances against translational variation.

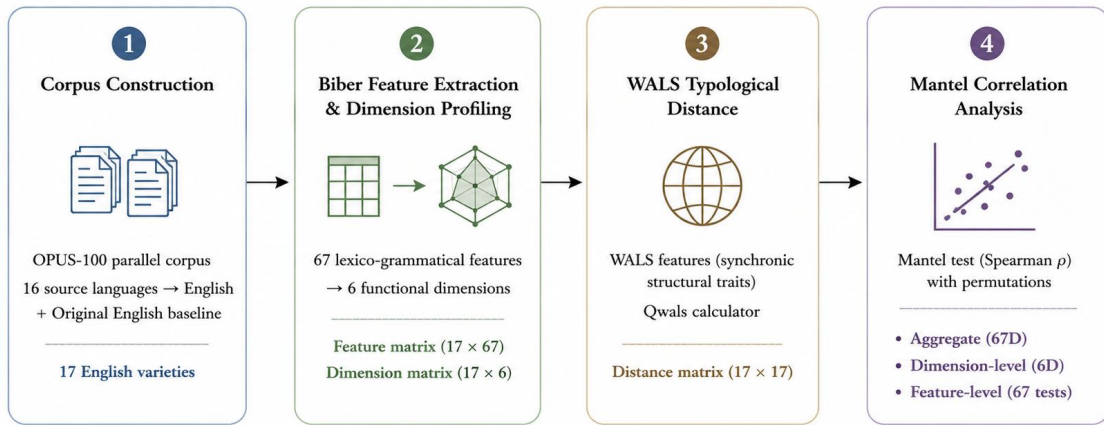


Figure 1. Overview of the experiment procedure

2. Methods

2.1 Corpus Construction

The dataset derives from the OPUS-100 parallel corpus (Tiedemann, 2012), from which we selected sixteen source languages aligned with English: Afrikaans, Amharic, Arabic, Assamese, Azerbaijani, Belarusian, Bengali, Breton, Bosnian, Catalan, Czech, Welsh, Danish, German, Greek, and Bulgarian. These languages span eleven sub-families: Germanic (West: af, de; North: da), Romance (ca), Slavic (South: bg, bs; West: cs; East: be), Hellenic (el), Semitic (ar, am), Indo-Aryan (bn, as), Turkic (az), and Celtic (br, cy).

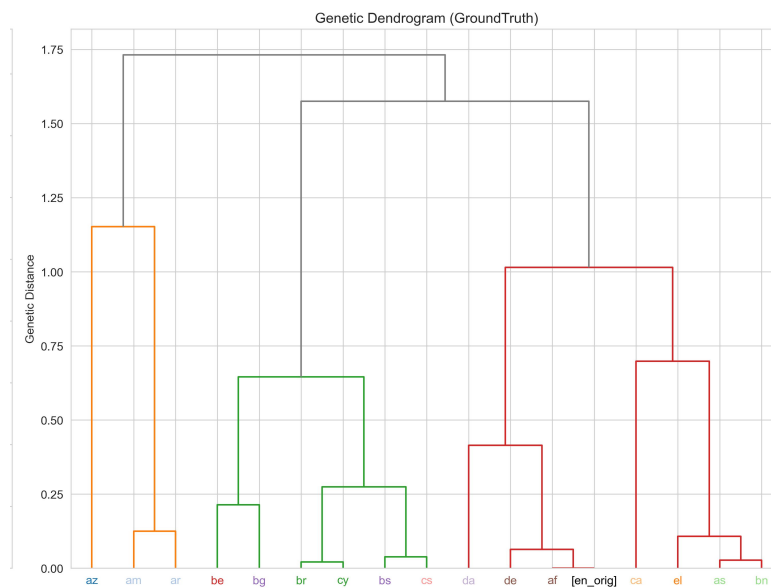


Figure 1 Genetic Tree of source languages used in this study

A three-pass preprocessing pipeline ensured unambiguous source-language attribution. Pass 1 scanned all sixteen XX-to-English parallel files across train, development, and test splits, recording for each valid English sentence the set of source languages with which it appeared. A sentence was deemed valid if it terminated with sentence-ending punctuation (`.`, `!`, or `?`) or contained at least three whitespace-delimited tokens; the stripped textual core was further required to be non-empty, non-numeric, and not a standalone abbreviation. Pass 2 retained only those sentences whose MD5 hash appeared in exactly one source-language pair, eliminating sentences shared across multiple language pairs where attribution would be ambiguous. After filtering, unambiguous sentence counts ranged from approximately 740,000 (Arabic) to 4,200 (Belarusian) per source language, a 177:1 imbalance that was noted but not resampled on the principle that per-language feature means, computed across all available sentences, provide the most reliable estimate of central tendency for each variety.

Original (non-translated) English was extracted from the source-side English files in the English-to-Esperanto, English-to-Spanish, English-to-Estonian, and English-to-Basque pairs within OPUS-100, subjected to the identical sentence-validation filter, and globally deduplicated, yielding approximately 500,000 unique sentences. The final corpus comprised 6.4 million sentences across seventeen varieties: sixteen translational and one original.

2.2 Feature Extraction

All sentences were processed through pybiber, a Python reimplementation of Biber's (1988) 67-feature extraction pipeline, using spaCy's `en_core_web_sm` model for tokenisation, lemmatisation, part-of-speech tagging, and dependency parsing (<https://github.com/browndw/pybiber>). The 67-feature set encompasses tense and aspect markers, pronominal reference of multiple subtypes, nominalisation density, agentless and *by*-passives, several structural types of complement and relative clauses, adverbial subordination, prepositional phrases, attributive and predicative adjectives, type-token ratio, mean word length, and lexical class distributions. Each feature was

normalised per 1,000 tokens of running text, with the exception of type-token ratio and mean word length, which were computed on raw token counts. Per-language group means were computed across all available sentences for each variety, producing a 17×67 data matrix, which was z-score standardised column-wise to prevent high-variance features from dominating distance computations.

2.3 Theory-Driven Dimension Profiling

Rather than relying on data-driven factor rotation, we adopted Biber's (1988) original six-dimension framework as a fixed theoretical lens. Of the 67 features, 56 were assigned to the six dimensions based on Biber's published loadings (Kim & Han, 2025); the remaining 11 features either cross-loaded across multiple dimensions or were not part of Biber's original scheme. Six functional dimensions are: Involved versus Informational Production, Narrative versus Non-Narrative Concerns, Explicit versus Situation-Dependent Reference, Overt Expression of Persuasion, Abstract versus Non-Abstract Information, and Online Informational Elaboration. For each language, a dimension score was computed as the mean of z-scored positive-loading features minus the mean of z-scored negative-loading features. The resulting 17×6 matrix was visualised as radar charts with small multiples grouped by language family.

2.4 WALs Typological Distance

Pairwise typological distances among all seventeen languages, including English, were computed via the Qwals calculator (Eronen et al., 2026) which derives ordinal distance scores from WALs feature data capturing word order configurations, morphological complexity, alignment patterns, and grammatical marking strategies.

2.5 Distance Computation and Mantel Testing

Pairwise Euclidean distances among all seventeen varieties were computed in the full 67-dimensional z-scored feature space and in the six-dimensional Biber space. For each representation, the Mantel test computed the Spearman rank correlation between the condensed upper-triangle WALs distance vector and the corresponding

Biber feature-space distance vector, with significance evaluated via 9,999 random permutations. The Mantel procedure was applied at three levels: a single aggregate test using the 67-dimensional distance matrix; six dimension-level tests, each using a distance matrix derived from a single Biber dimension; and 67 feature-level tests, each using a distance matrix derived from a single lexico-grammatical feature. Per-dimension and per-feature Mantel statistics were collected and exported.

3. Results

3.1 Translational English Varieties Exhibit Distinct Lexico-Grammatical Profiles

If the Translation Universals hypothesis operated unopposed, every translational English variety would converge toward the original English norm, producing radar shapes that cluster tightly around a single attractor. Our data refute this prediction. The seventeen varieties exhibit markedly different six-dimensional Biber profiles, and original English itself is not a gravitational centre (Figure 2). What we observe is dispersion: individual varieties occupy distinct, often widely separated equilibria across the six-dimensional space.

The heterogeneity is visible both across and within language families. Within the West Germanic group, Afrikaans, German, and original English diverge sharply on Dimension 1 (Involved vs. Informational Production) and Dimension 3 (Explicit vs. Situation-Dependent Reference). The Slavic family, represented by four languages across three sub-branches, shows weak within-family coherence: Bosnian and Bulgarian cluster on several dimensions, while Belarusian and Czech diverge substantially. The Celtic pair, Breton and Welsh, is the only family to exhibit partial radar-shape similarity. This initial descriptive evidence suggests that source-language affiliation does not determine translational output in any straightforward way.



Figure 2. Biber dimension radar profiles for seventeen English varieties, organised by language family. The small multiples reveal substantial within-family heterogeneity; original English (en_orig, shown in the main radar) is not a central attractor.

3.2 WALS Distance Predicts Lexico-Grammatical Divergence

To move beyond qualitative inspection, we correlated the pairwise WALS distance matrix against the pairwise Euclidean distance matrix in the full 67-dimensional Biber feature space. The Mantel test yields a significant positive Spearman correlation ($\rho = +0.189$, permutation $p < .05$), confirming that typologically more distant source languages tend to produce translational English varieties that are further apart in their lexico-grammatical profiles (Figure 3). The correlation is modest in magnitude, however, and the scatter reveals substantial dispersion: numerous language pairs with small WALS distances exhibit large Biber distances, and vice versa.

Disaggregating the analysis by Biber dimension reveals a more differentiated picture (Table 1). Three dimensions reach significance, but their directions diverge. Dimensions 1 and 3 exhibit significant positive correlations: as WALS distance between source languages increases, their translational varieties diverge more strongly along the involved versus informational and explicit versus situation-dependent axes. Both are anchored in features operating primarily at the lexical and phrasal level, such as nominal density, prepositional phrases, attributive adjectives, and nominalisations on the informational pole, and contractions, present-tense verbs, pronouns, and that-deletion on the involved pole. This pattern constitutes what we term direct mapping: source-language lexical and phrasal preferences are transferred onto English surface forms with minimal restructuring, such that greater typological distance between source languages produces proportionally greater divergence in the resulting translational varieties.

Dimension 6, by contrast, exhibits a significant negative correlation ($\rho = -0.206$, $p = 0.014$). This dimension is defined by four features: that-clauses as verb complements, demonstratives, that-relative clauses on object position, and that-clauses as adjective complements. These constructions operate at the clausal and discourse level, where information is elaborated through subordination and explicit connective marking. The negative correlation indicates that typologically more distant source languages produce translational varieties that are closer to each other on this

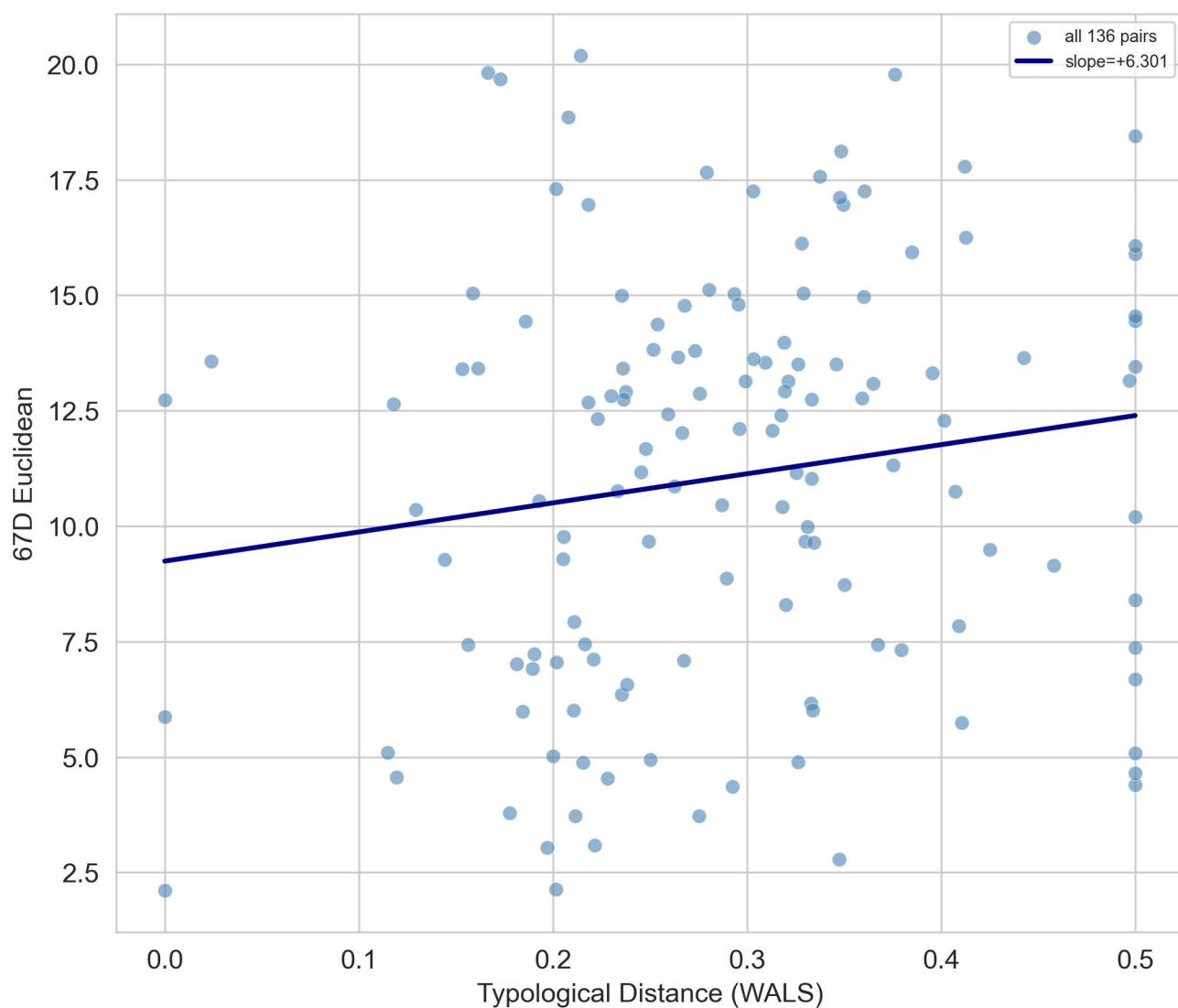


Figure 3. WALS typological distance versus 67-dimensional Biber Euclidean distance across 136 pairwise comparisons. Regression line shown. Spearman $\rho = +0.189$, $p < .05$.

Table 1. Mantel Correlations by Biber Dimension (WALS vs. Single-Dimension Distance)

Dimension	Spearman ρ	p (perm)
D1: Involved vs. Informational	+0.214	0.012 *
D2: Narrative vs. Non-Narrative	+0.116	0.177
D3: Explicit vs. Situation-Dependent	+0.213	0.014 *
D4: Overt Expression of Persuasion	+0.054	0.543
D5: Abstract vs. Non-Abstract	+0.031	0.728
D6: Online Informational Elaboration	-0.206	0.014 *

dimension. We interpret this inversion as evidence for a distinct mechanism: when source languages are too structurally divergent from English to permit direct clausal mapping, translators abandon structure-for-structure rendering and instead re-encode meaning into probabilistic English clausal patterns. Typologically distant languages, forced into deeper cognitive restructuring at the clause level, converge on canonical English strategies of complementation and relativisation, while typologically closer languages, cushioned by surface-level structural transparency, retain greater variation in their clausal organisation. Dimensions 2, 4, and 5 do not reach significance.

3.3 The Lexico-Grammatical Locus of Direct Mapping

The dimension-level analysis identifies where in the functional space WALS distance predicts translational divergence. To identify the specific lexico-grammatical features through which direct mapping operates, we computed single-feature Mantel correlations for each of the 67 Biber features individually against the WALS distance matrix. Table 2 presents the features reaching statistical significance.

The pattern is strikingly uniform. All significant features belong to the involved-production pole of Dimension 1, and all exhibit positive correlations. Time adverbials ($\rho = +0.314$) and contractions ($\rho = +0.310$) are the strongest individual predictors across the entire 67-feature inventory. Pronominal forms dominate: second-person, demonstrative, first-person, and *it* pronouns all reach significance, alongside *do*-support and *that*-deletion.

These features share a common profile. They are high-frequency, closed-class or highly grammaticalised forms that carry substantial pragmatic and register information while contributing minimally to propositional content. They also lack direct structural analogues across language families. A second-person pronoun exists in every language, but its discourse frequency and register distribution vary dramatically. A contraction like *don't* has no equivalent in a language without auxiliary negation. *That*-deletion depends on subtle interactions between verb semantics, subject animacy, and information structure that differ across languages. Because these features cannot be mapped one-to-one from source to target,

Table 2. All Significant Lexico-Grammatical Features (WALS vs. Single-Feature Distance)

Feature	Spearman ρ	p (perm)	Functional Category
f_59_contractions	0.3102	0.0003	Involved vs. Informational
f_50_discourse_particles	0.3032	0.0003	Involved vs. Informational
f_09_pronoun_it	0.3051	0.0005	Involved vs. Informational
f_49_emphatics	0.2885	0.0007	Involved vs. Informational
f_47_hedges	0.2811	0.001	Involved vs. Informational
f_06_first_person_pronouns	0.2796	0.0011	Involved vs. Informational
f_07_second_person_pronouns	0.2755	0.0011	Involved vs. Informational
f_11_indefinite_pronouns	0.2779	0.0012	Involved vs. Informational
f_48_amplifiers	0.2593	0.0029	Involved vs. Informational
f_44_mean_word_length	0.2415	0.0047	Involved vs. Informational
f_03_present_tense	0.2033	0.0176	Involved vs. Informational
f_52_modal_possibility	0.2021	0.0192	Involved vs. Informational
f_67_neg_analytic	0.1905	0.0272	Involved vs. Informational
f_13_wh_question	0.1717	0.0465	Involved vs. Informational
f_66_neg_synthetic	0.2611	0.0022	Narrative vs. Non-Narrative
f_08_third_person_pronouns	0.2235	0.0093	Narrative vs. Non-Narrative
f_05_time_adverbials	0.3141	0.0003	Explicit vs. Situation-Dependent
f_04_place_adverbials	0.2794	0.001	Explicit vs. Situation-Dependent
f_42_adverbs	0.277	0.0011	Explicit vs. Situation-Dependent
f_33_pied_piping	0.2296	0.0069	Explicit vs. Situation-Dependent
f_57_verb_suasive	0.2532	0.0033	Overt Expression of Persuasion
f_54_modal_predictive	0.229	0.0079	Overt Expression of Persuasion
f_24_infinitives	0.2016	0.0191	Overt Expression of Persuasion
f_37_if	0.1976	0.0221	Overt Expression of Persuasion
f_22_that_adj_comp	-0.185	0.0325	Online Informational Elaboration
f_56_verb_private	0.209	0.0153	None
f_36_though	0.1943	0.0241	None
f_20_existential_there	0.1782	0.0388	None
f_46_downtoners	0.1771	0.0394	None
f_29_that_subj	-0.1719	0.0453	None

their translational treatment is mediated by the translator's sensitivity to English register norms, a sensitivity modulated by the typological distance traversed. When the source language is structurally close, high cognate transparency may reduce vigilance toward these fine-grained functional distributions. When the source language is distant, wholesale restructuring enforces tighter adherence to English probabilistic norms. The uniform positivity of the correlations confirms that direct mapping operates most visibly on these features: greater typological distance systematically amplifies divergence in how high-frequency, pragmatically loaded markers are deployed in translational English. This is the quantitative signature of source languages systematically shaping their translational outputs through structural transfer at the lexical-phrasal level.

4. Discussion

4.1 Cognate Camouflage and the Arabic-German Anomaly

The aggregate correlation patterns describe central tendencies across 136 pairwise comparisons. These tendencies, however, obscure a striking anomaly at the level of individual language pairs. When the seventeen varieties are ranked by Euclidean distance from original English in the full 67-dimensional feature space, the closest translational variety is Arabic-to-English (distance 2.13), followed by Greek-to-English (3.09) and Afrikaans-to-English (4.57). The farthest are Assamese-to-English (15.94), German-to-English (13.41), and Danish-to-English (12.64). The WALS distances from English paint a different picture: Danish is typologically closest (0.118), followed by Afrikaans (0.119) and German (0.161); Arabic is in the middle at 0.202. If WALS distance linearly predicted translational divergence, German-to-English should be among the closest varieties; it is among the most distant.

The mechanism driving this anomaly is visible at the feature level. German translational English systematically overuses informational-production features relative to original English: nouns (+3.03 σ), prepositions (+2.97 σ), attributive adjectives (+3.04 σ), agentless passives (+3.08 σ), past participial clauses (+3.15 σ),

phrasal coordination (+3.23 σ), and nominalisations (+2.84 σ). These are the hallmarks of what German stylistics terms **Nominalstil**, the preference for dense, noun-centred, informationally compact prose. German-to-English translators, working with a source language sharing substantial cognate vocabulary and structural templates, map these constructions onto their surface English analogues with minimal restructuring, producing grammatical English sentences carrying a statistically massive Germanic information-density fingerprint. Arabic-to-English translators, confronting radically different clause-combining strategies and nominalisation patterns, enjoy no such cognate scaffolding; the wholesale syntactic reconstruction demanded by the typological distance drives the output closer to probabilistic English norms.

This pattern extends beyond German. Danish-to-English, the typologically closest pair (WALS 0.118), also exhibits a large Biber distance (12.64), yet Afrikaans-to-English, with an almost identical WALS distance (0.119), is much closer to the baseline (4.57). The Germanic family is internally polarised: two members produce highly divergent varieties, while the third tracks closely to original English. This within-family polarisation is the empirical signature of cognate camouflage: when surface-level lexical transparency is high, as it is across the Germanic family, the resulting translational output depends not on aggregate typological distance but on whether the specific lexico-grammatical preferences of an individual source language happen to map transparently onto English constructions. German and Danish *Nominalstil* maps transparently and produces massive divergence; Afrikaans, for reasons that merit further investigation, does not.

4.2 Two Mechanisms, One Negotiation

We propose the cognate camouflage hypothesis as a unified mechanistic account. The hypothesis holds that surface-level lexical transparency between structurally related languages reduces a translator's cognitive vigilance toward deeper syntactic interference. When a German translator encounters **die zu berücksichtigenden Faktoren**, the transparent cognates and shared participial morphology license a word-

for-word rendering that is grammatical English but carries the information-density profile of the German source. When an Arabic translator encounters an equivalent construction, the absence of cognate scaffolding forces a complete syntactic re-encoding, producing output structurally closer to original English norms. On this account, cognates function not as translation facilitators but as interference vectors: they license the covert persistence of source-language lexico-grammatical patterns beneath a deceptively idiomatic surface.

The interaction between these two mechanisms determines the equilibrium position of each translational variety. When typological distance is large, direct mapping is blocked at both the lexical-phrasal and clausal levels; the translator has no choice but to restructure, and the output converges toward English norms through the normalisation universal. When typological distance is small, direct mapping is structurally available, but cognate camouflage determines whether it actually occurs: if the specific lexico-grammatical preferences of the source language have transparent English analogues, direct mapping proceeds and produces divergence; if they do not, the output remains closer to the English baseline. This two-mechanism account reconciles the aggregate positive Mantel correlation with the existence of individual-pair anomalies and the dimensional asymmetries documented in Table 1.

An alternative but compatible mechanism involves asymmetrical hypercorrection. Translators between closely related languages develop acute awareness of the false-friend problem and may over-adjust away from constructions that feel source-like even when those constructions are natural in original English. Both mechanisms predict the same empirical signature, and distinguishing between them requires experimental data beyond the scope of this corpus study.

4.3 Implications for Toury's Law

These findings necessitate a degree-qualified amendment to Toury's Law of Interference. The law correctly predicts the existence of interference; our data demonstrate that its magnitude is not a simple linear function of typological distance. The aggregate Mantel correlation, while directionally positive, is modest, and the

individual-pair anomalies reveal that the translation negotiation is mediated by specific lexico-grammatical subsystems. The relevant question is not how far the source language is from English in aggregate WALS space, but which specific structural features map onto which English constructions, and how transparently. The ten features most strongly correlated with WALS distance are all high-frequency, pragmatically sensitive functional elements that corpus lexicology has identified as carrying register and stylistic information (Biber et al. 1999). Their sensitivity to source-language typological distance suggests that translation-mediated lexical encroachment operates most powerfully in the functional rather than the content vocabulary.

5. Conclusion

This study set out to determine whether WALS typological distance predicts the degree to which translational English varieties diverge in their lexico-grammatical profiles. Across sixteen translational varieties and 136 pairwise comparisons, the evidence supports a qualified affirmative. WALS distance correlates positively with feature-space distance at the aggregate level ($\rho = +0.189$, $p < .05$), with Dimensions 1, 3, and 6 reaching individual significance in divergent directions that illuminate distinct transfer mechanisms at the lexical-phrasal versus clausal levels.

Yet the most theoretically revealing patterns emerge at the pair level. The Arabic-German anomaly demonstrates that the translation negotiation is not governed by global typological similarity alone. Specific lexico-grammatical subsystems, particularly those associated with informational density and nominal style, can exhibit massive cross-lingual transfer when cognate transparency lowers the translator's restructuring threshold. The cognate camouflage hypothesis offers a testable account of this mechanism. These findings contribute a degree-qualified amendment to Toury's Law and demonstrate that the source language's role in shaping translational English is mediated by the interaction between typological distance and the specific lexico-grammatical subsystems susceptible to cross-lingual transfer.

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